McNamara’s old idea of a navy blockade was listed as one of the options in the memorandum that McCone had prepared for the president. It was reintroduced in the morning discussion with the president by Llewellyn Thompson, the former ambassador to Moscow, whom Kennedy had invited to participate in the deliberations. Thompson was critical of Rusk’s idea of issuing a warning: as Kennedy had implied, that would give Khrushchev an opportunity to threaten American missiles in Turkey and Italy. But he also did not like the president’s strike- without-warning option. “If you do this first strike, you would have killed a lot of Russians,” remarked Thompson. “What is your preference, Tommy?” asked the bewildered Bundy, since the ambassador seemed to be offering nothing but criticism. “My preference is this blockade plan,” responded Thompson.[12]

“What do we do with the weapons already there?” asked Kennedy, reacting to Thompson’s suggestion. “Demand they’re dismantled and say that we are going to maintain constant surveillance, and if they are armed, we would then take them out,” responded the ambassador. Kennedy was not convinced. He saw the benefits of the blockade but was afraid that in response to the blockade of Cuba, Khrushchev would “grab Berlin.” At the end of the day, with the tide turning against him, Kennedy was apparently wavering. According to the summary of the evening deliberations that he dictated into a secret tape recorder, he was considering “a limited blockade for a limited purpose.” But he was not rushing to make a decision. “It was determined,” dictated Kennedy into the microphone, “that I should go ahead with my speeches so that we don’t take cover off this, and come back Sunday night.”[13]

The speeches to which Kennedy referred were to be delivered in the course of a preplanned campaign trip to the Midwest. He was going to maintain the appearance that everything was normal, that there was no crisis of any sort, and that he was following a schedule determined long in advance.

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